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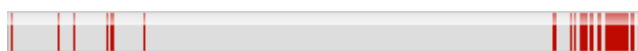
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Document Analysis

Linköping University | Institute for Analytical Sociology Master's thesis, 30 ECTS | Computational Social Science 2026 | Activating Antagonism – Populism and Ego-Network Structure among German MPs on Twitter Aktiverande Antagonism – Populism och egonätverksstruktur bland tyska förbundsdagsledamöter på Twitter Thomas Haase Supervisor: Károly Takács External supervisor: Philipp Lorenz-Spreen Examiner: Miriam Hurtado Bodell Linköping University SE-581 83 Linköping +46 13 28 10 00, www.liu.se Contents 1. Introduction

2. Literature Review
2.1. Populist Theories of Populism
2.2. Populism and Social Media
2.3. Language and the Meso Level
3. Data and Methods
3.1. Data and Operationalization ... [662 Words skipped]
... outstanding support I received during my bachelor's. You are a fantastic researcher and a great role model for me. Whenever I learn something new now, I realize that you laid the foundation for it years ago. I also want to thank all my dear friends in Gießen for the coffee chats in the library, lunches and dinners. It was a wonderful time.

Zuletzt und am Allerwichtigsten:

Danke Mama und danke Papa! Ihr seid die besten Eltern, die ich mir je hätte wünschen können. Ich habe euch sehr lieb. vi Generative AI Statement In accordance with the IAS generative AI policy, this statement documents the use of generative AI tools in the preparation of this thesis.

A distinction must be drawn between two categories of AI use. First, large language models are employed as a research instrument within the methodology itself, as described in the methods chapter. This methodological use forms part of the empirical contribution of the thesis and is documented and validated there in detail.

Second, generative AI was used in a limited capacity as an aid for complementary, noncore tasks, in line with what the policy ... [296 Words skipped] ... neoliberalizing regimes (Brown 2020) and destabilizing Western democ- racies (Lorenz-Spreen et al. 2022). This is hardly surprising considering the essence of populism.

Populism research has historically been divided by geographical focus, methods, and host ideologies (Hunger and Paxton 2022). Since 2016 the research landscape has been dominated by political science perspectives converging on populism as a discursive practice (Tuğal 2021). They almost uniformly adopt Mudde (2004)'s definition of populism as "an ideology that considers society to be ultimately separated into two homogeneous and antagonistic groups, 'the pure people' versus 'the corrupt elite', and which argues that politics should be an expression of the

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volonté générale (general will) of the people" (Mudde 2004:542).

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While theoretical work refines the concept largely within Marxist traditions, relational and systems-sociological perspectives have remained peripheral (Hunger and Paxton 2022; Tuğal 2021). This is puzzling, because Mudde's definition is itself relational: populism is constituted through the antagonism between two groups. Simmel already connected antagonism to group cohesion, noting that groups are "...held together by a shared aversion [...] to which entirely foreign elements are drawn by the commonality of an antagonism." (Simmel ... [661 Words skipped] ... includes a class component as the core of its definition (Yates and Mondon 2026). The definition is currently the most cited work on populism. This can be explained with the minimalism increasing the potential of connected communication for theorists discussing the work (Brubaker 2017; Luhmann 1987; Tuğal 2021; Urbinati 2019). Empirical studies operationalized the main dimensions of people-centrism and anti-elitism in surveys and finetuned bert classifier PopBert on german Bundestagspeeches (Akkerman, Mudde, and Zaslove 2014; Castanho Silva et al. 2020; Erhard et al. 2025). Often this minimal definition is combined with some other dimension like antipluralism or the distinction between left and rightwing populism (Castanho Silva et al. 2020; Erhard et al. 2025). Theorists combine the thin definition with institutional and substantive analyses when discussing populism but those are chosen rather arbitrary (Tuğal 2021). The minimal definition is part of the same family of subjectivist definitions as discursive and performative marxist and postmarxist definitions built on Laclau (2005); Tuğal 2021.

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Combining the minimal definition with more substantial categories of analysis not only thickens the analytic concept but also increases its theoretical richness. Brubaker (2017) criticised the minimal definition for only capturing his proposed vertical dimension without acknowledging the horizontal distinctions between "the people" and outside groups. For example one thickness-increasing addition would be that left-wing populism defines "the people" economically or politically against threats like globalization and imperialism, while right-wing populism defines them culturally or ethnically against outside groups and "internal outsiders" perceived as not belonging to the nation (Brubaker 2017). Engesser et al. (2017) use this thick definition to explore how they are used in a social media context and found that in Facebook and Twitter posts not one post contained all dimensions but that populist ideology was "fragmented" across posts.

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The more terms are added and connected the stronger and thicker the assumed ideology gets. Brubaker (2017) for example researches 5 different elites, more outsidegroups and 4 Literature Review the heartland. This comes with the caveat that the more the concept of populism is enriched the more it "lumps together" disparate political projects with disparate social bases and modes of action (Brubaker 2017; Medzhorsky and Lindberg 2024).

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The Elite The Media Politicians Large Companies The People Immigrants The poor Ethnic groups Religious groups LGBTQ+ The unemployed horizontal axis thick populism (Brubaker 2017) vertical axis thin populism (Mudde 2004) Figure 1: Vertical

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and horizontal dimensions of populism After Mudde (2004) and Brubaker (2017). The vertical axis captures the thin, minimal definition: "the people" constructed against "the elite". The horizontal axis captures Brubaker's thick extension, in which "the people" is additionally constructed against horizontal others. The labels along the axis are illustrative examples of such horizontal others; their position on the axis is not meaningful and the horizontal dimension is not equivalent to a left-right axis.

But is populism really such a densely connected set of concepts, aka an ideology? And is it democratic or antidemocratic? While those putting left and rightwing populism on one axis do not necessarily assume that they are part of the same dimension they use it to enrich ... [734 Words skipped] ... in the sense that it sees the people as homogenous, but when the people are invoked as diverse "plebs" instead of "ethos" one can also imagine a democratic populism that increases "plebs" representation within diversity-preserving constitutional constraints (Brown 2020; Yates and Mondon 2026). 2.2. Populism and Social Media The majority of social media populism studies understand populism as a form of communication since they analyse it on a social media platform connecting all of its users.

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Digital media use is consistently associated with higher populism, with causal evidence for far-right support and even ethnic hate crimes in democratic and authoritarian regimes (Lorenz-Spreen et al. 2022). The question is not whether social media matters but what it does structurally. The common explanation is affordance. Social media is cheap, viral and engagement-driven, exploited by populists for demagogic, antiestablishment and people-praising messaging including name-and-shame strategies (Gil De Zúñiga, Koc Michalska, and Römmele 2020). Cassell (2021) confirmed this through qualitative coding of populist leaders tweets across Latin America and Europe, ... [173 Words skipped] ... supporters avoid public broadcasters and expose themselves to alternative channels. "How to talk about and select media sources seems to have developed into a core component in the construction of a radical right group identity and a shared information 'safe space' for political information" (Stier et al. 2025). Group identity is built around the choice of information infrastructure itself. This ties populist communication to a legitimacy crisis rather than to a left-right axis. Analyzing 32 million tweets from parliamentary accounts in 26 countries, Törnberg and Chueri (2026) found that neither left-right nor populism alone explains misinformation spread. Both left and right-wing populists consume more misinformation, but only the rightwing believe themselves better informed. The radical right has built an alternative media ecosystem in symbiotic relationship with attention7 Literature Review economic platforms (Törnberg and Chueri 2026). Consistent with the Luhmannian reading above, once a functional system emancipates itself from its ... [1721 Words skipped] ... crisis. As Russia massed troops for what would become Europe's largest military offensive since WWII, Chancellor Scholz met President Biden to discuss Germany's Nord Stream 2 dependency. Domestically, Scholz's coalition split over a general vaccine mandate, with FDP Justice Minister Buschmann deeming it constitutionally dubious and proposing mandatory physician consultations for unvaccinated adults as a softer alternative.

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Current studies almost uniformly base their understanding of populism on Mudde (2004)'s definition of populism as "two homogeneous and antagonistic groups, 'the pure people' versus 'the corrupt elite', and which argues that politics should be an expression of the volonté générale (general will) of the people." (Mudde 2004:542).

While all operationalizations include a "pro-people" and "anti-elite" one of multiple third dimensions is often implemented as well like the inclusion of anti-pluralist attitudes, the distinction between leftwing and rightwing populism or agitating against horizontal outgroups like minorities (Aalberg et al. 2017; Castanho Silva et al. 2020; Meyer et al. 2025). Populist Attitudes are not only measured through surveys (Castanho Silva et al. 2020), but also through observational studies of political discourse on social media (Meyer et al. 2025) leveraging LLMs.

This study operationalizes the core dimensions of Mudde (2004)'s definition, People Attitude, Elitist Attitude, and Antagonism, by instructing a large language model through an annotation prompt (see Appendix). Each dimension is defined with explicit scoring anchors: People Attitude and Elitist Attitude are ... [9519 Words skipped] ... 0, "elite_explanation": "Is a powerful group or class targeted – or is the text criticizing a specific policy or individual without generalizing?", "elite_score": 0, "antagonism_explanation": "Does the text construct opposition between people and elite? How strong is the moral charge – merely wrong, culpable, or existential threat?", "antagonism_score": 50 Appendix C: Prompt } `` # INPUT TEXT TO ANALYZE: 51 Appendix C: Prompt 52 Appendix C: Prompt 53 Appendix C: Prompt Bibliography Aalberg, Toril, Frank Esser, Carsten Reinemann, Jesper Strömbäck, and Claes H. de Vreese. 2017. Populist Political Communication in Europe. Routledge Research in Communication Studies. New York: Routledge.

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